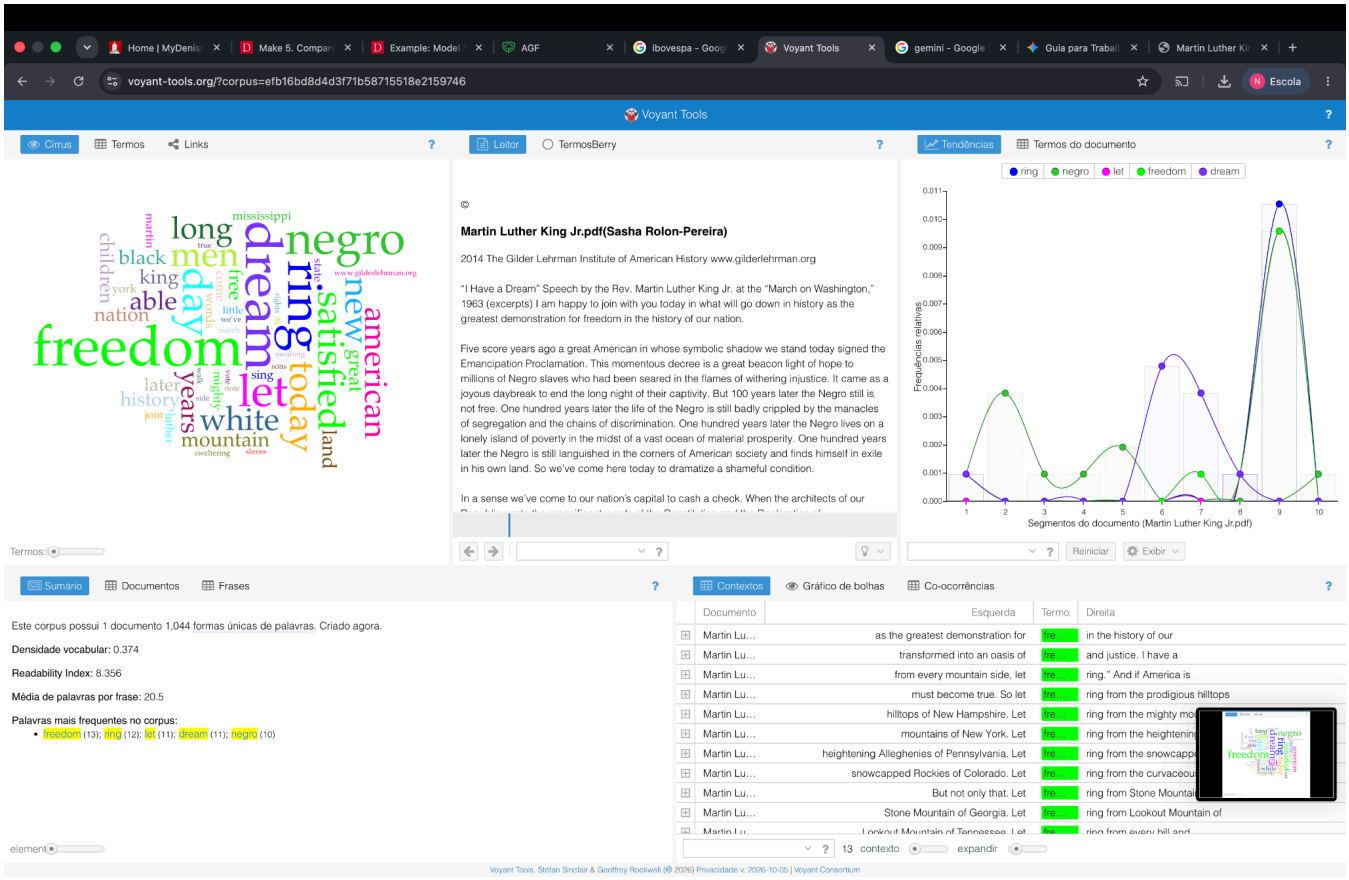
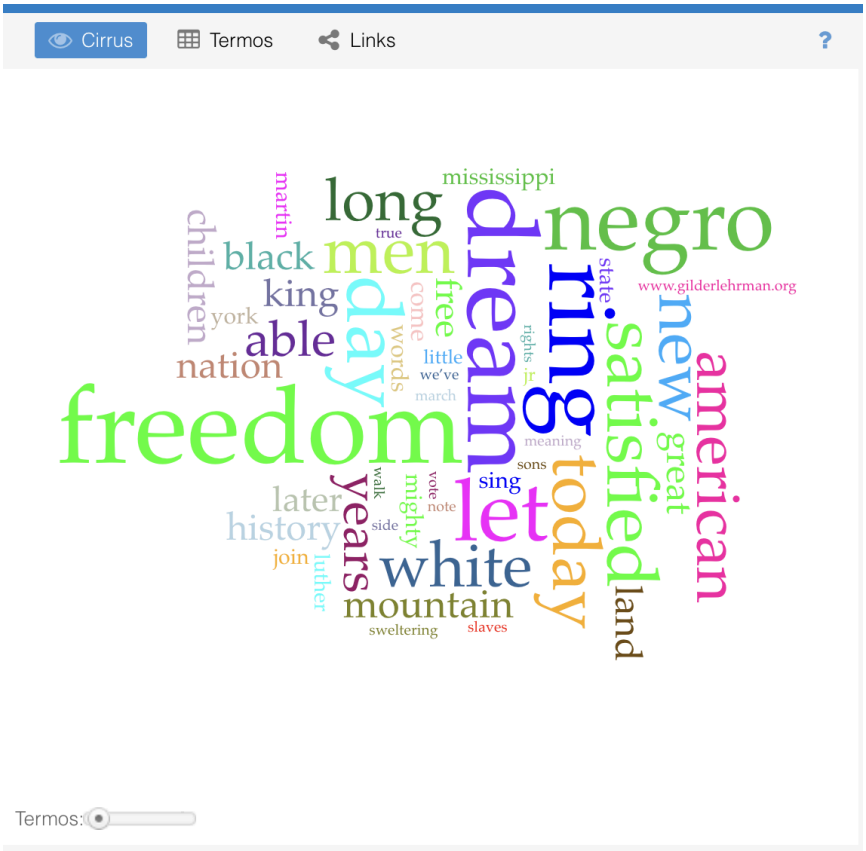
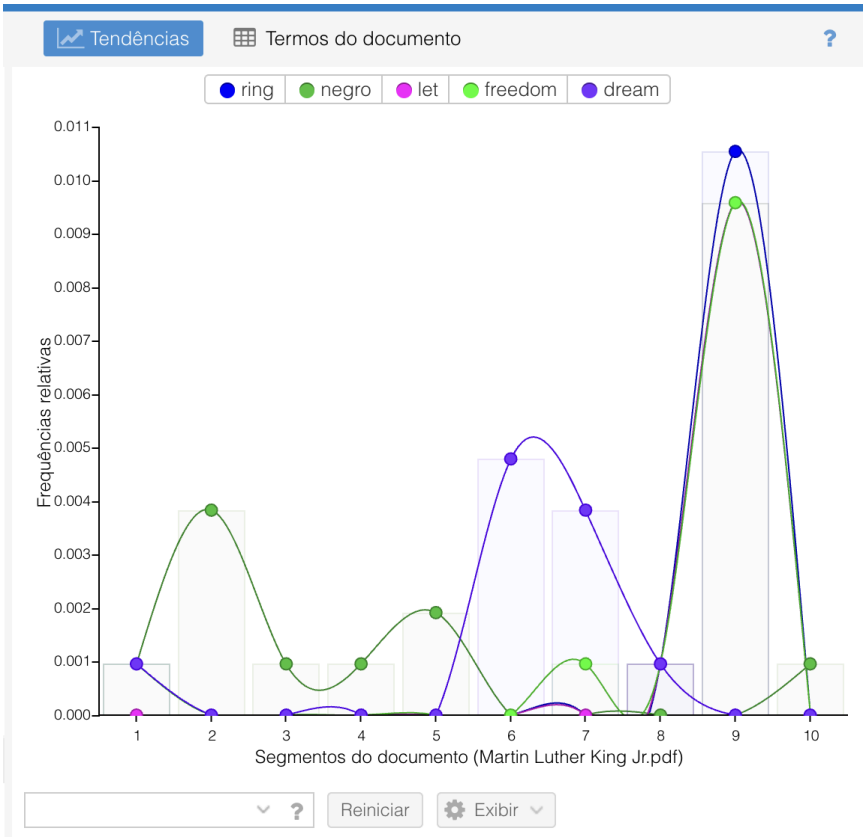
Make 5: How Machines Read

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Text Analyzed: "I Have a Dream" by Martin Luther King Jr.




Cirrus
Termos
Links
mississippi
martin
long
negro
true
children
black
men
dream
ring
state
www.gilderlehrman.org
king
free
come
satisfied
new
york
able
day
words
little
we've
rights
jr
nation
freedom
meaning
sons
great
american
sing
let
today
later
walk
vote
mighty
note
years
history
side
white
land
join
luther
mountain
sweltering
slaves
Termos:


Tendências
Termos do documento
ring
negro
let
freedom
dream
Frequências relativas
0.011
0.010
0.009
0.008
0.007
0.006
0.005
0.004
0.003
0.002
0.001
0.000
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10
Segmentos do documento (Martin Luther King Jr.pdf)
Reiniciar
Exibir

Voyant Analysis (Summary)

When analyzing the text with Voyant, I found that the most frequent content words were *freedom* (19), *ring* (12), *let* (11), *dream* (11), and *negro* (10). Through the Trends view, I mapped clear spatial patterns across the speech: the term *freedom* remains consistently present throughout, whereas *dream* forms a major peak in the second half, and *ring* spikes dramatically near the end. The Cirrus (Word Cloud) helped me visually emphasize these high-frequency terms, though it provided no explanation of how these words relate conceptually or emotionally.

Voyant helped me visualize structural repetition and cadence, specifically how King builds rhetorical momentum by shifting focus from initial themes of *freedom* to the repeated refrains of *dream* and *let freedom ring*. However, because it treated the text strictly as word counts, the tool failed to convey the historical weight, moral urgency, or emotional depth of King's message.

GPT Analysis (Summary)

Prompt used:

"Provide a rhetorical and literary analysis of Martin Luther King Jr.'s 'I Have a Dream' speech, focusing on themes, repetition, and tone."

To complement my quantitative findings, I prompted GPT to provide a structured literary and rhetorical critique. It identified core themes (racial justice, unfulfilled constitutional promises, and nonviolent resistance), detailed King's use of anaphora (repeating "One hundred years later," "We cannot be satisfied," "I have a dream," and "Let freedom ring"), and explained vivid metaphors such as the financial "promissory note" and nature-based contrasts between "sweltering heat" and "oases of freedom." It described the tone as shifting from urgent and indicative to prophetic and triumphant.

I observed that GPT's analysis sounded authoritative, fluent, and well-organized, closely mirroring human literary analysis. However, it presented high-level thematic synthesis without displaying exact word distributions or line citations unless I explicitly prompted it to do so.

Comparison

Through my analysis, I realized that Voyant and GPT represent two fundamentally different approaches to machine reading:

1. Voyant treats the text as a dataset of word frequencies, trends, and spatial counts. It made structural patterns transparent and verifiable for me (e.g., showing the exact distribution of *"freedom"* versus *"ring"*), but it lacked any capacity for semantic interpretation, tone, or context.

2. GPT treats the text as a cohesive linguistic whole. It synthesized themes and rhetorical structures fluently, offering interpretations that resembled human critical reading.

In short, I found Voyant to be transparent but limited, it showed its raw evidence clearly but could not explain why words matter. Conversely, GPT felt persuasive but opaque, it delivered compelling analysis based on learned statistical patterns without making its analytical process visible.

Reflection

This assignment revealed to me that machines do not "read" texts in the way human beings do; instead, they process statistical distributions and linguistic patterns. Voyant reads by counting and mapping tokens across a document, operating on the assumption that word frequency directly correlates with importance. While I found this approach useful for uncovering macro-level structure and repetition, I also noticed it can be misleading. A rare, single metaphor spoken once in a speech may carry more emotional resonance than a high-frequency common noun, yet Voyant cannot distinguish between them.

GPT, on the other hand, generated interpretations that sounded humanly empathetic and academically rigorous, explaining themes, metaphors, and tone with remarkable fluency. However, I recognized that this fluency can be deceiving. GPT does not actually "experience" or engage with the text as evidence; it predicts coherent narrative responses based on patterns learned from vast training datasets. It delivers authoritative conclusions without naturally proving how it arrived at them.

Ultimately, I concluded that what we gain from machine reading is speed, scale, and pattern recognition, allowing us to observe structural shifts that human readers might overlook. What we lose is critical accountability and contextual depth. Neither Voyant nor GPT possesses historical awareness, lived experience, or moral judgment. Consequently, I believe machine reading should not replace human reading, but rather serve as a tool to provoke better, more precise questions. The primary danger is not that machines misinterpret texts, but that human readers stop reflecting on how interpretations are constructed.

Attribution & AI Use

- Text: Martin Luther King Jr., "I Have a Dream" (excerpts, public domain / educational resource)
- Tools used: Voyant Tools; ChatGPT / AI Model
- GPT Prompt: *"Provide a rhetorical and literary analysis of Martin Luther King Jr.'s 'I Have a Dream' speech, focusing on themes, repetition, and tone."*
- Limitations: Voyant provides visualization without semantic interpretation or context; GPT provides persuasive interpretation without transparent evidence tracing or explicit data counts.